

content is compelling, we will go for it.

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RIL has invested ₹11,500 crore into the JV. What will that broadly go into?

We need to continue to invest in technology, building better UI/UX and on content. There are onerous cricket rights, and those obligations have to be serviced. The money is designed for everything and not for one specific purpose. It will be spent according to the business plan and building this company to redefine and lead the media business in India and elsewhere for a long time.

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What is the agreement with Disney with respect to their library and technology?

They are a shareholder, and we have a very comprehensive agreement to access their content library. Disney has a fabulous content portfolio and between that, HBO, Paramount, and Warner, there is a very rich content library.

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Disney will hold a little under 37% in the JV. Is there any indication on how long they will be around?

They have come in because they want to be there. Disney is a great

global company, and I don't see them exiting a market like India. It's just a pivot on both sides to build a bigger, greater business.

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In your conversations with Mukesh Ambani and Nita Ambani, there must have been a discussion on the vision and the long-term future of this behemoth. Can you share some details?

The vision is very simple. We believe India is going through a transformation. The video and the media and entertainment market in this country are at an early stage of evolution. The question is—can we be the default for every Indian who wants to consume content, and can we be available to them? Can we get the largest slice of time and attention from the largest number of Indians? That's what we want to achieve. India is a market where—particularly foreign media companies—come for 1.4-1.5 billion [users] and design solutions for 100-200 million, only to struggle. Everybody gets the attention of, say, 10-15-20-50 million customers but are mass. We know this country [and] want to go to every Indian wanting to consume video. **BT**

@szarabi,
@krishnagopalan

next round of bidding.

Nayar says the emergence of the Reliance-Disney combine is a dramatic change in the Indian sports broadcasting landscape. "One will see far reduced bid for the rights with only one serious bidder unless Meta, Amazon or other digital entities get aggressive. BCCI and IPL team owners need to be prepared for reduced IPL revenues," he says.

Reliance-Disney has the BCCI rights for all matches played in India and ICC tournaments (including the World Cup and Champions Trophy). "It will mean marginalisation of other sports media entities."

TECH, TECH, AND TECH

Will the Reliance-Disney entity play a significant role in digital? By winning the digital rights for the IPL, it stands to grab a large chunk of the revenue.

Harish Iyer, EVP (Media & Investments) at Interactive Avenues, India's largest digital agency, thinks the entity can do that through advanced technology, personalised content recommendations or expanding distribution across markets. "Cost efficiencies and a stronger market position help you compete against global platforms. Plus, there is an opportunity in synergistic partnerships with telecom operators to drive that growth," he says. Having local and global content means advertisers can target a wider range of demographics, making the campaign much more effective.

"Using data analytics, advertisers can gain insights on viewer behaviour and preference. Integrating the message across platforms is a seamless way to reach out to the audience," Iyer says.

The Reliance-Disney deal's success will depend on its prowess in the technology sphere. Amaresh Godbole, CEO (Digital Technology Business), Publicis Groupe India, says Netflix has been "the global gold standard for technology, user experience and innovation for video content delivery."

Godbole says Reliance-Disney has a lot of data and an understanding of user behaviour and could use AI to milk the data. "It's also worth looking at new technologies such as LLMs, which could change the navigation and discovery game."

With scale not an issue, the growth opportunity is clear. In the tech-driven sector, what does the horizon hold? As Captain Jack Sparrow, the Disney character in *Pirates of the Caribbean*, says: "Now, bring me that horizon". **BT**

@krishnagopalan